

The 22nd Annual Report on Sustainable Practices highlights the achievements of the University of California's comprehensive sustainability program in 2025. It includes progress in sustainable operations required by UC's Sustainable Practices Policy as well as sustainability accomplishments in education, research, patient care and public service. In keeping with this year's theme, the 2025 report highlights UC's sustainable innovations.

The University's sustainability commitment began in 2003 with a Regental action that led to the adoption of a Presidential Policy on Green Building Design and Clean Energy Standards in 2004. Since adopting that policy, UC has expanded the scope to include climate, transportation, building operations, waste, procurement, food, water, health and well-being, health care operations and sustainability performance, as well as anti-racism, diversity, equity, and inclusion. The Sustainable Practices Policy includes all 10 campuses, five academic health centers, UC Agriculture and Natural Resources, Lawrence Berkeley National Laboratory and UC Office of the President.

Climate Change

UC's greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions are reported on a calendar year basis, so the 2025 report includes emissions through the end of 2024. Emissions rose approximately 3% from the previous year but remained about 8% below pre-pandemic levels, even as student enrollment increased 5% within the same period. Scope 1 emissions (e.g., burning gas and oil) increased 2% while scope 3 emissions (e.g., commuting, business travel, waste) decreased 2%.

Scope 2 emissions (indirect emissions from purchased power) increased 18% due to changes in local emission factors and more grid electricity purchases while the largest cogeneration plant in the UC system was offline for engine replacements. Despite this temporary increase, locations remain committed to achieving UC's 100% clean electricity goal, which will be reported on next year. This was the first year UC was required to report scope 3 data for solid waste and business travel, including backfilling this data to the 2019 baseline year.

After all locations completed state-funded energy system decarbonization studies in fall 2024, the systemwide Pathways to a Fossil-Free UC Task Force compiled the results of these studies in its final report, "Evaluating decarbonization strategies across the University of California." Locations are navigating changes in federal and state funding and location-specific financial constraints, making it essential to follow the task force's recommendation to implement decarbonization pathways in phases.

In December 2024, UC locations adopted local targets for reducing GHG emissions by 90% no later than 2045, along with interim targets for scope 1 reductions that outline a path to meeting the 90% reduction goal. To support these targets, locations are drafting updated climate action plans to identify more specific actions to implement in pursuit of their scope 1, 2 and 3 climate commitments. The updated climate action plans will be submitted in June 2026 and will consider GHG emission reductions across all three scopes of emissions. They will also assess equity impacts and climate resilience as a continuation of each location's recent work in these areas.

Diversity, Equity, Inclusion and Justice

The University made progress in assessing how efforts to implement sustainable practices can avoid harm and benefit all University community members. Climate protection remained a significant focus, with findings and recommendations in "Evaluating decarbonization strategies across the University of California" exploring ways to ensure that the transition to fossil-free campus energy infrastructure includes plans for helping campus operational staff gain the skills needed to operate new energy systems and equipment. Campuses and academic health centers will integrate the decarbonization report's recommendations into their updated climate action plans.

Clean Energy and Energy Efficiency

Procuring clean energy and using energy efficiently play a major role in reducing GHG emissions. The University continues to pursue energy efficiency across its operations. In this reporting year, UC locations worked to retain energy reductions while managing increased occupancy and activities. Energy efficiency projects and high efficiency new buildings avoided approximately $100 million in energy costs in 2024, avoiding a total of approximately $623 million since 2010.

The University has also made significant progress toward its clean energy goals and is ranked first among colleges and universities in green electricity use by the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency. On its campuses, UC has installed more than 100 solar projects representing 55 megawatts of capacity. Off campus, the University continues to expand its renewable energy commitments in support of decarbonization. UC has three operating utility-scale solar projects in California under contract, representing 110 megawatts of power, and a 15-megawatt battery that came online this year. Additionally, UC signed its first-ever wind energy contract in 2023, with the expected electricity generation of 85 megawatts, equivalent to the total electricity consumption of UC Merced, UC Riverside, UC Santa Barbara and UC Santa Cruz combined. UC's own electric service provider, UC Clean Power, has provided 100% clean electricity to UC locations since 2018 and supplies approximately 48% of the University's purchased electricity.

Food

In fiscal year 2024–25, approximately 16% of campus food purchases and 23% of academic health center food purchases met one or more sustainability criteria. This represents over $35 million going to sustainable food suppliers. Nine locations were able to increase their sustainable food spend, while others saw reductions in sustainable food spend related to food cost inflation, budget cuts, and difficulties tracking and reporting data. Dining services, procurement teams and Bonnie Reiss Leading on Climate Sustainable Food Services Fellows collaborated to address these challenges, through such initiatives as streamlining product purchasing to reduce costs, modifying language in requests for proposals to prioritize sustainable food options and connecting campuses with local and sustainable producers.

Of the University's total food and beverage spend, 31%, or over $63 million, was on plant-based food items. Ten locations are already on track to meet the policy goal of at least 25% spend on plant-based food by 2030.

General Sustainability Performance Assessment

All nine undergraduate UC campuses participate in the Association for the Advancement of Sustainability in Higher Education's Sustainability Tracking, Assessment and Rating System (STARS). Six of the nine campuses held a Gold rating in fiscal year 2024–25. Two campuses, UC Berkeley and UC San Diego, have a Platinum rating, the highest STARS ranking. UC Merced previously received a platinum rating and is planning to submit for an updated rating in 2026. UC Berkeley, UC Riverside and UC Santa Cruz earned ratings in the latest version of STARS 3.0, a more comprehensive rating framework. Additionally, five academic health centers received sustainability awards from Practice Greenhealth. UC Irvine Health and UC San Diego Health (Hillcrest and Jacobs Medical Centers) received the Top 25 Environmental Excellence Award, Practice Greenhealth's highest honor for hospitals. UC Davis Health, UCLA Santa Monica Medical Center and UCSF Health received the Greenhealth Emerald Award, recognizing the top 20% of applicants.

Green Building

UC now has 467 Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design (LEED) certifications for green buildings. These projects represent approximately 41 million square feet. UC does not allow the on-site combustion of fossil fuel, such as natural gas, for space and water heating in new buildings or major renovations, except under special circumstances. The University currently has 45 all-electric buildings, exceeding 4.5 million square feet, and another six facilities (1 million square feet) that do not use electricity for space or water heating. Another 50 electric buildings, accounting for over 11 million square feet, are in planning, design, or under construction. UC locations are pursuing Parksmart certification for nine new parking projects, adding to the University's five existing certified facilities.

Health and Well-Being

The University made progress toward its healthy vending and chemicals of concern goals over the past year. Nine campuses and five health locations reported fiscal year 2023–24 data on food and beverage vending machine spend. Healthy food accounted for 23% of all food from vending machines, and healthy beverages accounted for 34% of the beverages sold. This is the first time this data has been reported. The Systemwide Sustainability Policy Health and Well-Being Working Group also provided recommendations to improve reporting on green spend data to better represent UC's goals to purchase furniture free of chemicals of concern.

Procurement

The University and its procurement staff continued to partner with strategic suppliers to improve sustainability practices. Academic health centers generated nearly $12 million in cost savings through medical device reprocessing, avoiding almost 250,000 pounds of medical waste. UC also analyzed data from 32 strategic suppliers representing over $138 million in total spend during fiscal year 2024–25. Within that spend, the University found that 62% of electronics, 84% of indoor office furniture, 53% of cleaning supplies and 20% of office supplies met UC's requirements on minimum or preferred green spend, as outlined in the Sustainable Procurement Guidelines. This represents nearly $88 million in spend on products meeting green certification standards. UC Health locations also reported their green spend, with 98% of electronics and 23% of office supplies meeting green spend criteria, contributing an additional $21 million in spend on products meeting green certification standards. Analysis of UC's support of small businesses, which is an additional component of UC's sustainable procurement goals, is presented to the state each year and can be found online.

Sustainable Building Operations and Laboratories

Through fiscal year 2024–25, the cumulative number of green-certified laboratories totaled 253, a 37% decrease from the previous year. The reduction reflects staffing shortages that resulted in some campuses pausing their certification programs. Additionally, several programs are undergoing significant redesign.

Transportation

The University continues to implement sustainable transportation programs and related GHG emission reduction strategies. In fiscal year 2024–25, 75% of students and employees telecommuted or commuted to campus by walking, biking, transit, vanpool or carpool. Despite this progress, only seven of the 13 locations that reported data are on track to meet the goal of reducing single-occupancy-vehicle rates by 10%. Systemwide, 51% of all new fleet vehicles acquired were battery-electric, plug-in hybrid or electric hybrid vehicles, up 2% from the previous year. UC's goal is that alternatively powered vehicles account for at least 50% of all vehicle acquisitions at each campus. Seventy percent of all sedans and minivans acquired met the UC policy, falling short of the ambitious goal of 100%. UC locations now host over 2,400 active electric vehicle (EV) charging stations, an increase of approximately 10% from last year, along with many additional EV-ready spaces to support fleet and commuter vehicles.

UC Health

As part of continued operational and capacity expansion, UC Health locations included innovative design features to reduce energy use and GHG emissions in both new and existing health care facilities. UC Health also continued its efforts to address scope 3 GHG emissions from sources like transportation and supply chain. UC Health published an inventory of its scope 3 emissions showing that the largest sources of emissions are from the supply chain. Based on that analysis, UC Health initiated a project to reduce the GHG emissions from the largest sources of emissions within its supply chain.

Water

Total water consumption systemwide increased slightly in 2024–25 compared with the previous year. Ten out of 15 locations met the 2025 goal. Locations that did not meet the 2025 goal cited a range of technical challenges, including increases in square footage growth that do not correlate with population growth, aggressive water conservation programs prior to the baseline period, limited recycled water supplies to offset potable water use and limited funding.

Waste

The University continued focusing on the phase-out of single-use plastics. The number of locations that have completely phased out plastic bags rose from 12 the prior year to 15. As campuses continued to struggle with fully phasing out single-use plastic foodware and beverage bottles, the UC Global Climate Leadership Council selected 13 projects across the UC system to pilot reusable or compostable alternatives to single-use plastic foodware. Projects include supporting awareness campaigns, piloting reusable dishes and to-go ware, and installing hydration stations.

Five campuses are on track to meet the 2025 goal of reducing per capita municipal solid waste generation by 25% from the 2015–16 baseline year. Two of those campuses are also already on track to meet the 2030 goal of a 50% reduction. Of the five campuses that are not yet on track to meet the 2025 goal, two of them are within 2 percentage points of the goal. UC Health locations have made significant strides toward their 2025 goal of 25 pounds or less of waste per adjusted patient day. Two UC Health locations are on track to meet the 2025 goal, and the remaining three achieved significant reductions, bringing them closer to meeting the goal. Campuses also continue working toward reaching the goal of diverting 90% waste reduction from the landfill. The University is actively seeking diversion opportunities and innovative ways to approach waste management for both campus and health locations.

Academics

Faculty and student leadership continue to be fundamental in achieving these operational goals while also continuing and expanding the University's position at the forefront of sustainability research, education and public service.

The second year of state-funded climate action research grants saw continued progress by faculty researchers helping California communities understand, fight and adapt to climate change, highlighted by a conference in Sacramento with grantees, state agencies and community partners. Administered by UC, the state-funded California Firefighter Cancer Prevention and Research Program awarded eight grants totaling $6 million in 2024 to advance research on reducing cancer and cancer risk among firefighters. California's Fifth Climate Change Assessment is co-led and supported by UC faculty and researchers serving as study authors, expert reviewers and executive editorial team leaders. In 2024–25, UC Research Initiatives directed nearly $10 million — two-thirds of a total $15.5 million investment in Multicampus Research Programs and Initiatives — to fuel inter-institutional, interdisciplinary discovery in climate and resource-related challenges. These investments address urgent realities such as heat exposure and water scarcity, push the boundaries of sustainable agriculture through agroecological farming and cultivate the future of engagement with multidisciplinary climate action.

The University continued to expand its educational offerings related to climate change and sustainability last year. UC San Diego launched the Jane Teranes Climate Change Education Requirement for incoming first-year students in fall 2024. Students are now required to complete a one-quarter course designed to empower them with the knowledge and skills needed to confront the urgent global challenge of climate change. At the systemwide level,

the UC President's Global Climate Leadership Council funded an expansion of systemwide offerings such as the Bending the Curve course platform. In the 2024–25 academic year, Bending the Curve content was offered by four UC campuses (UCLA, UC Riverside, UC San Diego and UC Santa Cruz) and universities around the world (Appalachian State University, National Taiwan University and Stockholm University). The course also expanded to six high schools through the National Education Opportunity Network, which enables high school students from historically underserved communities to take college courses, and course content was licensed by two organizations providing access to their networks of more than 100 universities around the globe and thousands of teachers and administrators. In collaboration with Bending the Curve, the Center for Climate, Health and Equity partnered with the American Medical Association to provide continuing medical education on climate change and health. Between October 2024 and May 2025, the UC-generated curriculum was accessed by 800 health care providers.

UC's environmental sustainability goals are rooted in student activism, beginning more than two decades ago when students encouraged the Regents to approve UC's first green building and clean energy policy in 2003. The Bonnie Reiss Leading on Climate Student Fellowship program, formerly known as the Climate Neutrality Initiative and Global Food Initiative Student Fellowships, funds student-generated research, operational projects, and engagement activities across all UC locations. In 2024–25, the program supported 73 fellows who joined a growing network of 877 fellows since the program's launch a decade ago.

Academic Senate divisions continued to advance climate action and education through campus-level climate crisis committees.